

“We Built This Alley!”

They're still at school, but change is already on their agenda

Jyotsna Rege

Tech empowers people. With the government not taking sufficient initiatives in making technology trickle down to the underprivileged, it's up to NGOs and NPOs to attempt to achieve this. Ours is too huge a country for the NGOs to achieve much in terms of raw numbers, but examples and precedents can be set.

Take the example of a slum in the Govindpuri area of New Delhi, which had been facing an acute water shortage. The children in the slum decided to act, and with the aid of an NGO in their area, divided themselves into groups, allotted themselves tasks, and created a PowerPoint presentation titled “Water Project.” The presentation was screened during the chief minister's visit to the NGO, and its effect was immediate: water pipes were soon being laid to the area!

The NGO was Katha (www.katha.org), and the children were students of KITES, the Infotech school that Katha runs.

Beyond Tales

Founded in 1989, Katha's basic ideology is to impart knowledge through the vast storehouse of wisdom that Indian folklore and tales comprise—hence the name. In partnership with British Telecom, KITES (Katha Info Tech School) was opened in 2001 as an extension to the Katha School of Entrepreneurship. The school, located in Govindpuri, was the vision of Geeta Dharmarajan, executive director of Katha. Most of the students are from Govindpuri, and the school has introduced computer education for the children—and not just for the older students. Parvinder Kaur, principal of KITES, says, “Even the youngest students, who are about six, are taught to use MS Paint and other basic software. The images they create are amazing.”

“We realised that computers and their applications were no longer something reserved for the elite. Computers had entered mainstream businesses. Simultaneously, we found there was a large job market for data operators and designers in the city. Besides receiving education, we wanted to ensure that the youth from the school are employed so that they feel self-reliant. And so, we initiated a school with curricula related to computers to provide vocational training.”

“Its Our Home”

The children at the school have been actively participating in GReDI, the Govindpuri ReDesign initiative—an ongoing project started two years ago. These computer-savvy 12 to 17-year-olds, under the supervision of their teachers, have actually undertaken the complete restructuring of the housing system in the area. They're using mapping and designing tools for this purpose, and plan to put forward a

